



THE PRACTICAL DEVICE CARE & REMOTE SUPPORT GUIDE

Clear, local advice for protecting, diagnosing, repairing, and getting expert help for phones, laptops, and computers in Freetown.

BridgeTech IT Services

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Welcome

Technology should help you work, learn, and stay connected - not become a source of stress. This guide gathers BridgeTech IT Services' practical repair knowledge into one place. It is written for device owners, families, students, and small businesses in Sierra Leone.

Use it to make safer decisions at home, prepare for a repair, and know when professional help will save time, data, or money.

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1. Protect your device in Freetown

Heat, dust, humidity, and unstable power make a few habits especially important for electronics in Freetown.

Power protection is essential

Use a quality surge protector or UPS for computers, routers, televisions, and chargers. Power fluctuations can damage power supplies, charging circuits, motherboards, and storage devices.

Keep devices cool and clean

Do not use laptops on beds or cushions that block vents. Clean external vents carefully and schedule internal cleaning when fans become loud or the device overheats. Dust and heat shorten component life.

Create a backup routine

Keep important files in at least two places: a cloud service and an external drive, or two separate external locations. Test that your backup can be opened before you need it.

Quick rule: If a device smells burnt, becomes unusually hot, or has a swollen battery, turn it off and seek professional help immediately.

2. Phone essentials

Most phone problems can be made worse by improvised cleaning or repeated charging attempts. Start with safe checks.

Cracked screens

A cracked screen can allow moisture and dust to reach the display and internal components. Stop using a screen with loose glass. Back up your data if the touch screen still works, then arrange a replacement.

Charging problems

Try a known-good cable and adapter first. Do not use needles, pins, or metal objects inside a charging port - they can permanently damage the contacts. A loose cable or charging only at one angle often needs a professional port inspection.

Battery health

A lifting back cover, swelling, extreme heat, or sudden shutdown can indicate a failing battery. Do not puncture, bend, or continue charging a swollen battery. Keep phones out of direct heat and avoid charging beneath pillows.

Before any repair: back up photos, documents, contacts, and authenticator codes where possible.

3. Laptop and computer recovery

Slow performance and startup failures commonly come from software load, storage health, heat, or power damage.

When a laptop will not turn on

Unplug it and inspect for overheating or burnt smells. For models with removable batteries, a safe first step is removing the battery, holding the power button for 30 seconds, connecting power only, and trying once. Do not repeatedly force-start a device that smells burnt.

When a laptop is slow

Check startup programs, free disk space, software updates, and malware protection. Old hard drives and low RAM can also cause severe slowdown. An SSD upgrade is often the most noticeable improvement for compatible laptops.

When to stop and seek help

Unexpected blue screens, clicking drives, liquid exposure, repeated shutdowns, or a device that cannot detect its storage require careful assessment. Continuing use can increase repair cost or reduce recovery chances.

Practical upgrade tip: Ask for compatibility checks before buying RAM or storage. Not every laptop supports every upgrade.

4. Data safety and recovery

Data loss is time-sensitive. Your first actions have a direct effect on how much can be recovered.

Deleted or formatted files

Stop using the affected drive, memory card, or phone immediately. New activity can overwrite data that may otherwise be recoverable.

Dead devices

A dead laptop or phone does not automatically mean the files are gone. Storage is often separate from the failed power components, but recovery should be assessed carefully before repair attempts.

Safe preparation for service

Bring the correct charger and, when possible, an external drive for recovered files. Explain what data matters most. Do not share passwords in writing; enter sensitive credentials yourself when needed.

Remember: Recovery is not the same as backup. A reliable backup is the best protection against loss.

5. Water damage: the first 60 minutes

Liquid damage can cause corrosion and short circuits. Fast, calm action gives your device the best chance.

Do immediately

Power off the device, unplug it, remove accessories, and keep it away from charging. If practical, remove the battery only if it is designed to be removed easily.

Avoid these mistakes

Do not charge it, use a hair dryer, place it in rice, or keep pressing buttons to test it. Heat can spread damage and rice does not remove corrosion from internal circuits.

Get professional assessment quickly

Professional cleaning and inspection can remove moisture and corrosion. The earlier the device is assessed, the better the chance of preserving both the device and its data.

Emergency: A wet device that is powered or charging should be disconnected safely as soon as possible.

6. Repair, upgrade, or replace?

A good decision balances repair cost, device age, future needs, and the value of your data.

Repair makes sense when

The device is otherwise reliable, the issue is limited, replacement parts are available, and the repair cost is reasonable compared with an equivalent replacement.

Upgrade makes sense when

A computer is functional but slow because of a hard drive, limited memory, or outdated software. An SSD, RAM upgrade, or cleanup can significantly extend useful life.

Replacement makes sense when

The device has repeated major failures, repair costs approach the value of a dependable replacement, or it can no longer meet your work, school, or security needs.

Ask for a clear quote: it should separate diagnostic work, parts, labor, warranty, and any optional upgrades.

7. Remote support: secure help from anywhere

BridgeTech remote support is designed for software, email, performance, Wi-Fi, backup, and business IT issues that do not require a workshop visit.

What remote support can help with

Software installation, email setup, Windows or Mac cleanup, printer and network troubleshooting, security checks, backup setup, and guided training are common remote tasks.

How a session works

You request support, agree a schedule and payment method, then receive guidance to open AnyDesk. You remain present and approve the connection. The technician works only on the issue you approved.

Stay safe during a session

Never share bank passwords, mobile-money PINs, one-time verification codes, or recovery codes. Type sensitive information yourself. End the session if anything feels unexpected and contact BridgeTech directly.

AnyDesk checklist: download only from the official AnyDesk website, install it for your operating system, allow required Mac permissions, and share your AnyDesk address only with your verified BridgeTech technician.

8. Your service checklist

Use this checklist before bringing in a device or starting a remote-support session.

- Back up essential files, photos, and contacts.
- Bring the correct charger, cable, and any relevant accessories.
- Write down the error message and when the problem began.
- Tell the technician about liquid exposure, drops, power surges, or attempted repairs.
- For remote help, make sure your internet is stable and AnyDesk is installed.
- Keep passwords, PINs, and verification codes private; enter them yourself.
- Ask for the estimated cost, turnaround time, and warranty before work begins.

BridgeTech IT Services

Professional device repair, IT support, and remote technical services in Freetown, Sierra Leone.

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This guide provides general device-care information. It is not a substitute for a professional diagnostic when a device shows signs of electrical damage, severe overheating, swelling, or liquid exposure.